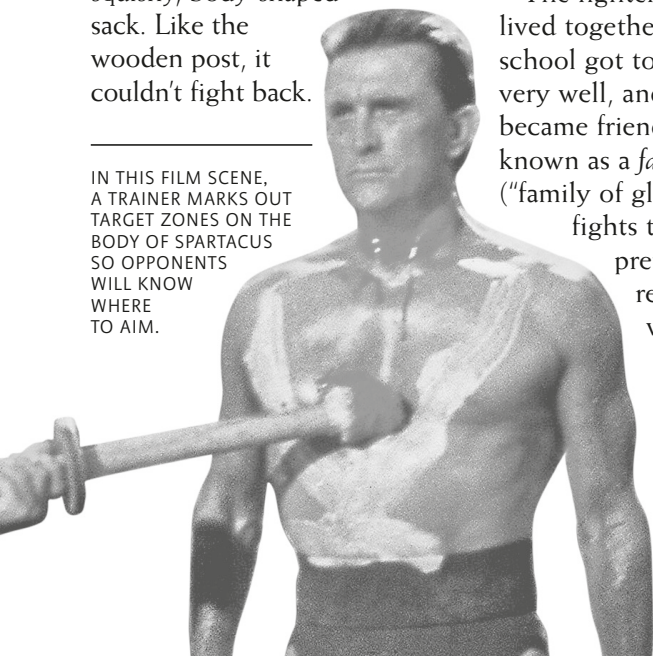


bulging muscles. Injuries and illnesses were treated by the school's highly skilled doctors.

Teachers and techniques

Trainees were taught by older warriors who were once gladiators themselves. They had retired from the arena and gone on to work as teachers. All schools had a small arena where teachers taught their pupils how to fight. At first, new gladiators practiced fighting against a tall wooden post, called a *palus*, which was rammed into the ground. The trainees were told to imagine the post was their enemy, and they attacked it with weapons chosen by their teacher. Sometimes they fought against a "man of straw"—a soft, squishy, body-shaped sack. Like the wooden post, it couldn't fight back.

IN THIS FILM SCENE, A TRAINER MARKS OUT TARGET ZONES ON THE BODY OF SPARTACUS SO OPPONENTS WILL KNOW WHERE TO AIM.



WEIRD WORLD

IN 73 BCE, SPARTACUS, A SLAVE WHO WAS A GLADIATOR, LED A REBELLION AGAINST ROME. IT TOOK 10 ROMAN LEGIONS TO DEFEAT HIM. ABOUT 6,000 OF SPARTACUS'S FOLLOWERS WERE CRUCIFIED.

The trainees learned how to fight by using wooden swords and other blunt weapons. It was far too risky to let them use real weapons until they could be trusted with them—just in case they used them against their teachers and escaped from the school or tried to commit suicide. Only after lots of training were they allowed to practice against other gladiators.

The fighters who trained and lived together at a gladiatorial school got to know each other very well, and they probably became friends. They were known as a *familia gladiatoria* ("family of gladiators"). The fights they had were

pretend, and no one really got hurt. But when it was time to entertain the crowd and fight for real, the gladiators knew they might end up killing their friends